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Session 1 Homework Answer Key: Jeremiah 29:1–14

How (Not) to Read the Bible · Oct 18, 2026 · @Eric

Background

Jeremiah 29 is a letter from the prophet Jeremiah in Jerusalem to Judeans who had been taken captive to Babylon. Knowing who they were and what they were hoping for changes how verse 11 reads.

Babylon took Judah's people in waves:

Year	What happened
605 BC	A first group of young nobles is taken, including Daniel (Dan 1:1–6)
597 BC	King Jehoiachin, the royal family, officials, and craftsmen are deported (2 Kgs 24:10–17). **This letter is written to them** (Jer 29:2).
586 BC	Jerusalem and the temple are destroyed (2 Kgs 25). This hadn't happened yet when the letter was written.

When the exiles received this letter, Jerusalem and the temple were still standing. It was easy to believe they would be home soon.

The false prophets. Read Jeremiah 27–29 together. In chapter 28, the prophet Hananiah publicly announced that God would bring the exiles home within **two years** (28:3, 11). Prophets in Babylon were saying the same thing (29:8–9, 21). Jeremiah's letter contradicts them. God's plans are good, but they are not the quick rescue everyone wanted to hear about.

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Answers

Before you start

What have you always thought Jeremiah 29:11 means? There's no wrong answer here. Many people have heard it as a personal promise that God will make their plans succeed. Hold your answer and compare it with what you find below.

Observe

1. Who wrote this letter, and to whom? Where are they living? The prophet Jeremiah, writing from Jerusalem (v. 1). He wrote to the elders, priests, prophets, and people Nebuchadnezzar had taken captive to Babylon, including King Jeconiah (Jehoiachin), the queen mother, officials, and craftsmen (vv. 1–2). The letter was carried by two of King Zedekiah's officials, Elasah and Gemariah (v. 3).

2. What does God tell them to do in verses 5–7? Does that sound like a quick rescue? Build houses and live in them, plant gardens and eat their produce, marry, and have children and grandchildren. Then: *"Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf"* (v. 7).

No, this is not a quick rescue. These are things you do when you'll be somewhere for decades. They're even told to pray for Babylon, the city that conquered them. Notice too that God says **"where I have sent you."** He claims the exile as his own act.

3. How long until God's promise is fulfilled? Seventy years (v. 10; see also 25:11–12). That's a full lifetime (Ps 90:10). Most of the adults reading this letter would die in Babylon, and their grandchildren would see the return. Later Scripture says the promise was kept (2 Chr 36:21–23; Ezra 1:1–4; Dan 9:2).

4. What were the false prophets saying? That the exile would end soon, and the exiles would be home quickly. God says they were prophesying "a lie" in his name and that he did not send them (vv. 8–9; compare Hananiah's "two years" in 28:3). Verses 21–23 name two of these prophets and announce God's judgment on them.

Interpret

5. Who is the "you" in verse 11? One person or a whole people? A whole people. The "you" is plural in Hebrew. God is speaking to the community of exiles, his covenant people, not to one person.

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6. Finish the sentence: "The timeless truth here is that God…" A good answer: *God keeps his promises to his people, even through long seasons of hardship and waiting, and he calls them to live faithfully where he has placed them.*

A few things that support this:

- "Plans" (v. 11) means God's settled purposes. It is not a promise about our career plans.
- "Welfare" in verses 7 and 11 is the Hebrew word *shalom*, meaning wholeness and well-being.
- Verses 12–14 ("you will seek me and find me, when you seek me with all your heart") echo Deuteronomy 4:29–31 and 30:1–5. God is keeping the promise he made through Moses to restore his people when they turn back to him.

Apply

7. If a friend posted Jeremiah 29:11 before a big job interview, how would you gently share what you learned? Start from what's true and encouraging, not by correcting them. For example:

"I love that verse too. I learned something cool about it: God said it to people who were stuck in exile for 70 years. So it's not really a promise that every interview goes well. It's a promise that God is faithful and has good plans for his people even when things are hard. Whatever happens tomorrow, that's true for you."

Avoid making them feel foolish. The goal is to give the verse back with its full meaning, which is actually more comforting.

Where this points

- **The near fulfillment:** In 538 BC, King Cyrus of Persia let the exiles go home, and the temple was rebuilt (Ezra 1–6).
- **The bigger fulfillment:** Two chapters later, God promises a new covenant: his law written on the heart and sins forgiven (Jer 31:31–34). Jesus says this new covenant comes through his blood (Luke 22:20). The return from Babylon was real, but only Christ ends the deeper exile of sin. That's how verse 11's "future and a hope" reaches us: all God's promises find their "yes" in Christ (2 Cor 1:20).
- **For us now:** The New Testament calls Christians "exiles" too (1 Pet 1:1; 2:11). Verse 7 still speaks to us: be faithful, put down roots, and seek the good of the place where God has put you.

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One-sentence takeaway: Jeremiah 29:11 isn't a promise that our plans will work out. It's a promise that God's plans for his people always do, even when that takes longer than we'd like and leads through hard places.